Valentin Nikolaev

Senior PHP Backend Engineer

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Summary

Backend engineer with 15+ years of experience, a PHP background in Laravel and Symfony, and five years building production systems in Go. Work includes APIs, automation, high-volume communications and event-driven services. Brings hands-on expertise in performance optimization, production reliability, cloud migrations, and CI/CD, together with five years of leadership experience. Comfortable owning backend systems from architecture and delivery through monitoring and operational improvement.

Skills

- **Backend:** PHP, Laravel, Symfony, Go, REST APIs, Microservices, Event-Driven Systems
- **Cloud & Platform:** AWS, Kubernetes, CI/CD
- **Data & Messaging:** MySQL, PostgreSQL, Elasticsearch, RabbitMQ
- **Reliability:** Prometheus, Performance Optimization

Experience

Simple.life | Software Developer

November 2023 - October 2026

- Designed and owned a backend support automation platform connecting Zendesk, Intercom, and internal services through a unified API orchestration layer.
- Implemented automated triage workflows and helped roll out new support automation scenarios.
- Migrated business-critical workflows from Zendesk to Intercom's real-time engine and improved routing consistency and operational responsiveness.
- Built resilient message-delivery pipelines with fallback logic, retries, and monitoring for continuity during incidents and peak load.

Technologies: Go, REST APIs, Zendesk, Intercom, Monitoring, Backend Integrations

CRURATED | PHP Software Developer - Part-time Consulting Engagement

August 2024 - January 2026

- Architected and led development of an internal event analytics system supporting product metrics, reporting, and business insights.
- Defined a versioned event schema and modular routing to multiple downstreams, including webhooks and S3.
- Built fault-tolerant pipelines with retries, observability, delivery guarantees, and backpressure handling.
- Reduced implementation time for new analytics streams from several days to under four hours through modular design.

Technologies: PHP, Event-Driven Systems, Queues, AWS EventBridge, Webhooks, Amazon S3, Observability

airSlate | Senior Software Developer / Technical Lead

February 2021 - August 2023

- Identified and optimized API, query, and database bottlenecks, improving backend performance and stability during peak load.
- Developed a Laravel/Symfony logging package aligned with interservice communication standards.
- Supported planning and release delivery, distributed team assignments, tracked engineering performance, and conducted more than 20 technical interviews.

Technologies: PHP, Laravel, Symfony, MySQL, Elasticsearch, RabbitMQ, AWS, Kubernetes, Prometheus, Helm, GitHub Actions, ArgoCD

Hyprr | Technical Lead

November 2019 - January 2021

- Helped bring a creator-focused social and digital-asset platform from prototype to closed beta in under six months.
- Managed 10 developers and remained hands-on in backend delivery, architecture, CI/CD, and product planning.
- Defined the technology roadmap with the CTO and shaped microservice and serverless architecture and reliability practices.

Technologies: PHP, Go, Laravel, Mezzio, Phalcon, PostgreSQL, MySQL, AWS, Kubernetes, Microservices, REST APIs, Prometheus, Jaeger

PDFfiller | Software Developer / Backend Team Lead

October 2016 - November 2019

- Led five backend engineers building a transactional email service that handled about 3 million messages in a typical month.
- Made key technical decisions across development and production reliability, with deep ownership of DNS, DKIM, SPF, DMARC, and feedback loops.
- Guided the team through Black Friday and Cyber Monday peaks of up to 10 times the usual traffic while maintaining service continuity.

Technologies: PHP, Laravel, MySQL, Elasticsearch, RabbitMQ, AWS, REST APIs, Email Infrastructure, SRE

Education

MSc in Computer Science, National Technical University, Kharkiv, Ukraine | 2003 - 2008

Languages

- Ukrainian: Native
- English: Professional working proficiency / Upper-intermediate